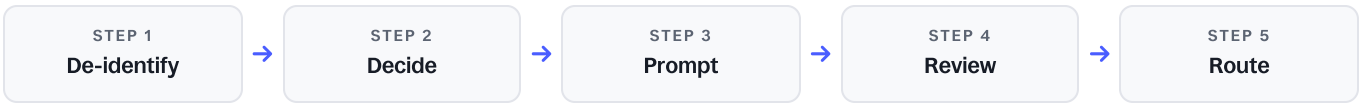
PHI SAFETY · AI SUMMARIZATION

How to Safely Use ChatGPT to Summarize Medical History

De-identify, summarize, verify, and route for review.

This guide helps healthcare teams use ChatGPT to organize medical history summaries while protecting protected health information (PHI), avoiding unsafe conclusions, and keeping human review at the center of the workflow.

THE SAFE-SUMMARY WORKFLOW



COURSE OVERVIEW

What this course helps you do

ChatGPT can help organize and condense clear medical history information — but it should not receive protected health information, make clinical judgments, reconcile uncertainty on its own, or create final chart content without review.

FIVE COURSE FOCUS AREAS

1. **Privacy risks**
   Spot privacy risks before using ChatGPT.
2. **Task fit**
   Decide when ChatGPT is appropriate for medical history summarization.
3. **Higher-risk cases**
   Limit AI use in higher-risk or uncertain cases.
4. **Uncertainty**
   Convert uncertainty into questions instead of conclusions.
5. **Consistency**
   Use a repeatable checklist to make safe summarization consistent.

KEY REMINDER

ChatGPT can support structure and clarity. It should not replace clinical judgment, source review, or final human ownership. **Never paste PHI into an unapproved AI tool.**

LESSON 1 · DE-IDENTIFY

Spot privacy risks before using ChatGPT

MAIN IDEA

Treat any patient detail as identifiable unless it cannot reasonably be linked back to a specific person.

Safe de-identify workflow

1. Define the summary goal first.
2. Remove direct identifiers — names, dates of birth, addresses, phone numbers, record numbers, and other patient-specific details.
3. Include only the minimum necessary clinical facts.
4. Ask for structure and condensation, not a diagnosis.
5. Compare the output against the source note.
6. Route the reviewed draft through the normal clinical review path.

DO	DON'T
✓ Ask for a concise timeline	✕ Paste a full intake note with PHI
✓ Ask for a problem list based only on provided facts	✕ Ask ChatGPT to diagnose
✓ Use de-identified information	✕ Ask ChatGPT to fill in missing details
✓ Review against the source note	✕ Put output into the chart without review

EXAMPLE

A medical assistant prepares a handoff summary from a new-patient intake form. They remove identifiers; keep diagnoses, medications, allergies, and key events; ask for a brief timeline; correct a missed allergy; and send the draft for clinician sign-off before charting.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Remove PHI before anything leaves the chart. Use ChatGPT for structure, not clinical conclusions.

LESSON 2 · DECIDE

Decide when ChatGPT fits the task

MAIN IDEA

Use ChatGPT for low-risk organizing of clear facts — not for clinical judgment, uncertainty, or time-critical decisions.

CHATGPT MAY FIT WHEN

- ✓ The facts are clear and stable
- ✓ The source note is reliable
- ✓ The task is summarization or organization
- ✓ The output will be reviewed by a human
- ✓ No clinical decision depends on the AI output alone

IT DOES NOT FIT WHEN

- ✗ Notes conflict
- ✗ Details are missing or unclear
- ✗ The situation is urgent or high-stakes
- ✗ The summary requires clinical judgment
- ✗ The task involves diagnosis, causality, or recommendations

Ask before using ChatGPT

- Are the facts clear?
- Is the task low-risk?
- Will a qualified person review the output?
- Are the sources reliable?
- Can I de-identify the information?
- Does any decision rest on the AI output alone?

EXAMPLE

A staff member is asked to summarize outside records before a same-day visit. The packet includes conflicting medication lists and a recent emergency visit with unclear details. The safest choice is to skip ChatGPT and route the source notes to the clinician for direct review.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Decide whether ChatGPT is appropriate before you paste anything.

LESSON 3 · CONSTRAIN

Handle higher-risk summaries and AI uncertainty

MAIN IDEA

When uncertainty rises, treat AI output as a draft hypothesis — not a clinical fact.

Risk signals to watch for

- Direct identifiers
- Substance use details
- Conflicting problem lists
- Unclear medication history
- Recent emergency visits
- Mental health details
- Conflicting dates
- Missing source notes
- Sensitive diagnoses
- Unresolved findings

Safe handling workflow

1. Flag the risk signals.
2. Remove identifiers.
3. Use only a minimal de-identified fact set.
4. Ask ChatGPT to label unknowns clearly.
5. Ask for “source needed” where facts are missing.
6. Route the draft with source references.
7. Document what was excluded and why.

SAFE PROMPT LANGUAGE

“Summarize only the facts provided. Do not infer missing information. Label unclear items as ‘unknown’ or ‘source needed.’ Do not provide diagnosis, recommendations, or clinical conclusions.”

KEY TAKEAWAY

Constrain inputs, force unknown labels, and route the draft for review with its sources.

LESSON 4 · PRESERVE UNCERTAINTY

Convert clinical uncertainty into questions

MAIN IDEA

When uncertainty is clinically meaningful, the summary should not make the situation sound more certain than it is. Keep the source's hedging language intact.

DO NOT TURN "POSSIBLE" INTO "CONFIRMED"

✕ "Patient had sepsis."	✓ "Sepsis is mentioned, but cultures and source details are missing."
✕ "Stroke confirmed."	✓ "Possible TIA or stroke; history is unclear and requires clinician confirmation."
✕ "Medication started on March 4."	✓ "Anticoagulant start date differs across sources."
✕ "Cancer history confirmed."	✓ "Cancer history is referenced, but source documentation is incomplete."

Watch for words that signal uncertainty

- "Rule out"
- "Question of"
- "Unclear"
- "Possible"
- "Suspected"
- "Pending"
- "Cultures missing"
- "Conflicting dates"
- "Source not available"

KEY TAKEAWAY

Convert guesses into unclear labels and review questions: what is known, what is unclear, what source is needed, and what the clinician should review.

LESSON 5 · REPEAT & IMPROVE

Use one repeatable safety checklist

MAIN IDEA

Consistency turns safe intent into safe outcomes — even when the team is busy.

BEFORE Before using ChatGPT

- [ ] Define the summary goal
- [ ] Confirm the task is appropriate
- [ ] Remove direct identifiers
- [ ] Include only minimum necessary facts
- [ ] Check for higher-risk or unclear details

DURING When prompting

- [ ] Ask for a timeline and problem list
- [ ] Ask for structure and condensation only
- [ ] Tell it not to diagnose or recommend
- [ ] Tell it to label unknowns
- [ ] Ask for “source needed” where missing

AFTER After receiving output

- [ ] Compare against the source note
- [ ] Correct errors or omissions
- [ ] Confirm allergies, medications, and major history
- [ ] Preserve uncertainty
- [ ] Route through the normal review path

LOOP Improvement loop

- [ ] Track misses for one week
- [ ] Identify recurring variation points
- [ ] Update the checklist wording
- [ ] Share the corrected process

KEY TAKEAWAY

Use the same checklist every time, then improve it based on real misses.

COPY-AND-ADAPT REFERENCE

Safe ChatGPT prompt template

For medical history summaries. Adapt the wording to your workflow — but keep every guardrail.

PROMPT

"Using only the de-identified facts below, create a concise medical history summary for review.

- → Do not diagnose.
- → Do not recommend treatment.
- → Do not infer missing information.
- → Do not add facts that are not provided.
- → Label unclear items as 'unknown' or 'source needed.'
- → Preserve uncertainty where the source is unclear.

Please organize the response into a brief timeline, active or relevant problems, current medications, allergies, and unclear items for clinician review.

De-identified facts: [paste minimum necessary facts here]"

NEVER PASTE

Do not paste patient names, dates of birth, addresses, phone numbers, record numbers, Social Security numbers, full dates, or other identifiable details into ChatGPT.

Ask ChatGPT to organize into

1. Brief timeline
2. Active or relevant problems based only on the facts provided
3. Current medications listed in the source
4. Allergies listed in the source
5. Unclear items or questions for clinician review

QUICK REFERENCE · ONE-PAGE CHEAT SHEET

Safe ChatGPT use for medical history summaries

Five steps to keep every AI-assisted summary private, accurate, and reviewed.

STEP 1 De-identify

Remove PHI and include only the minimum necessary facts.

STEP 2 Decide

Use ChatGPT only for clear, low-risk organizing tasks. Skip it when information is high-stakes, conflicting, urgent, or unclear.

STEP 3 Constrain

Ask ChatGPT to summarize only provided facts, label unknowns, and avoid guesses.

STEP 4 Review

Compare the summary to the source note. Correct errors, omissions, and unsafe certainty.

STEP 5 Route

Send the draft through the normal clinical review path before charting or handoff.

REMEMBER

AI output is a draft. Human review owns the final result.

PRACTICE WORKSHEET

Apply this to your workflow

Work through these with your team. Print one copy per summarization task you plan to support.

1 **What recurring medical history summary task could this support?**

2 **What is the summary goal?**

3 **What information must be removed before using ChatGPT?**

4 **What minimum clinical facts are needed?**

5 **Is this a low-risk organizing task or a higher-risk clinical judgment task?**

6 **What uncertainty signals should we watch for?**

7 **What should ChatGPT be instructed not to do?**

8 **Who reviews the summary before it is used?**

9 **Where does the reviewed summary go?**

10 **What is one repeated mistake or variation we should track this week?**

11 **What checklist line could prevent that mistake?**

12 **What is our fallback when ChatGPT is not appropriate?**